

Poverty and social exclusion in Spain (2014–2025): an exploratory analysis of the AROPE indicator using official data

This analysis explores the evolution of the AROPE indicator (At Risk of Poverty or Social Exclusion) in Spain using official data from the Spanish National Statistics Institute (INE), with particular attention to its distribution across sex and age groups. The objective is not merely to describe the aggregate evolution of the risk of poverty or social exclusion, but to identify patterns, persistent inequalities, and differential dynamics across social groups that may serve as a starting point for future explanatory hypotheses or more advanced research based on microdata.

Defined by Eurostat as the European Union's main harmonised metric for monitoring poverty and social exclusion, the AROPE indicator constitutes a central tool within the EU's social objectives for 2030. Its analytical value lies in moving beyond a strictly monetary understanding of poverty by incorporating complementary dimensions of material vulnerability and labour market integration. Specifically, it combines three main components: the risk of monetary poverty, defined as income below 60% of the national equivalised median after social transfers; severe material and social deprivation, linked to the inability to afford goods, services, and activities considered essential for a decent standard of living; and very low work intensity at household level, associated with persistent disconnection from the labour market.

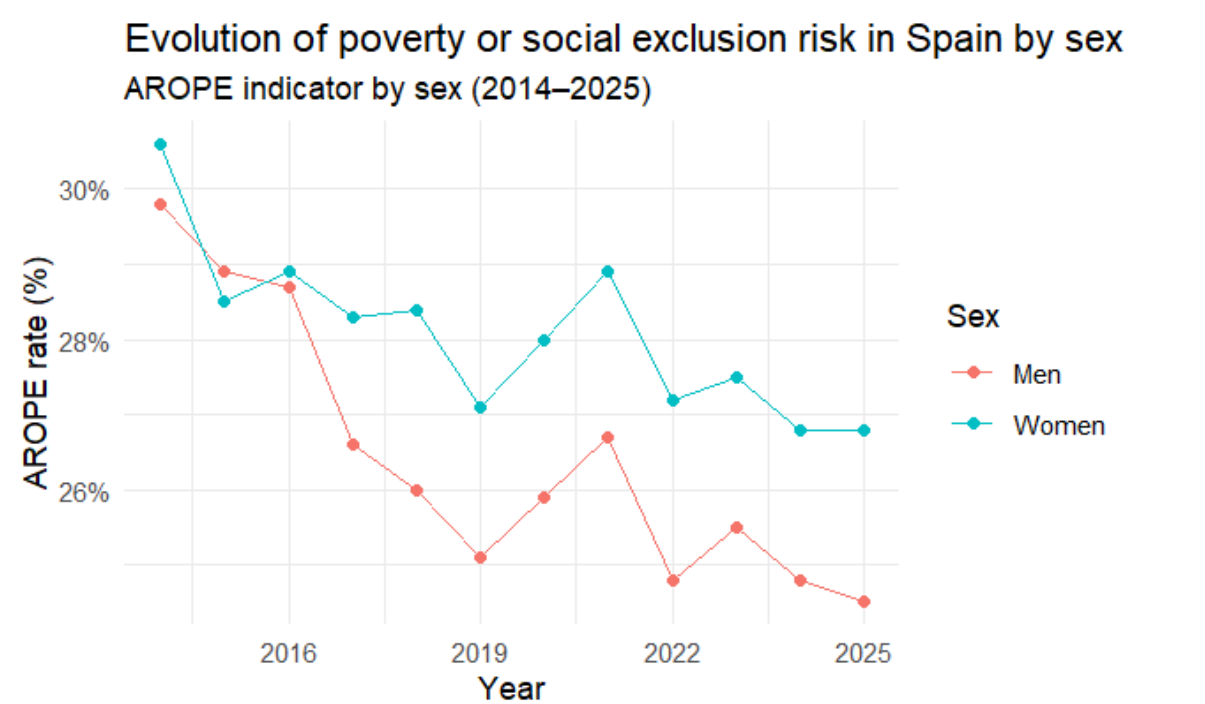
From this perspective, AROPE offers a richer analytical framework than purely income-based poverty indicators, as it captures multiple—and often overlapping—forms of social vulnerability. Its political relevance is equally significant, given that it serves as the principal benchmark for monitoring the European Union's commitment to reducing poverty and social exclusion by 2030. In this context, analysing its evolution in Spain allows us to observe not only aggregate trends, but also internal inequalities across social groups following potentially distinct trajectories.

Although this analysis adopts an exploratory and descriptive approach, the results already point to several relevant findings. Overall, Spain shows an aggregate improvement in the indicator over the period analysed (2014–2025); however, this evolution is not distributed evenly across social groups. The persistence of gender gaps, the high exposure of children and young people to poverty or social exclusion risk, and the contrasting trajectory of other groups such as older populations suggest the presence of structural dynamics deserving closer examination.

It should be emphasised, however, that this work does not seek to establish causal relationships or identify definitive explanatory mechanisms, but rather to describe observable patterns and propose plausible avenues for interpretation. Furthermore, the analysis is based on aggregated data rather than individual-level microdata, which limits the capacity to examine with precision the specific factors that may explain certain dynamics. An additional methodological consideration is that the AROPE indicator underwent definitional adjustments from 2021 onwards, particularly in the

measurement of severe material and social deprivation and household work intensity criteria, which advises some caution when interpreting especially fine-grained temporal comparisons.

How has the AROPE rate evolved by sex?



Based on data from the Spanish National Statistics Institute (INE), AROPE indicator.

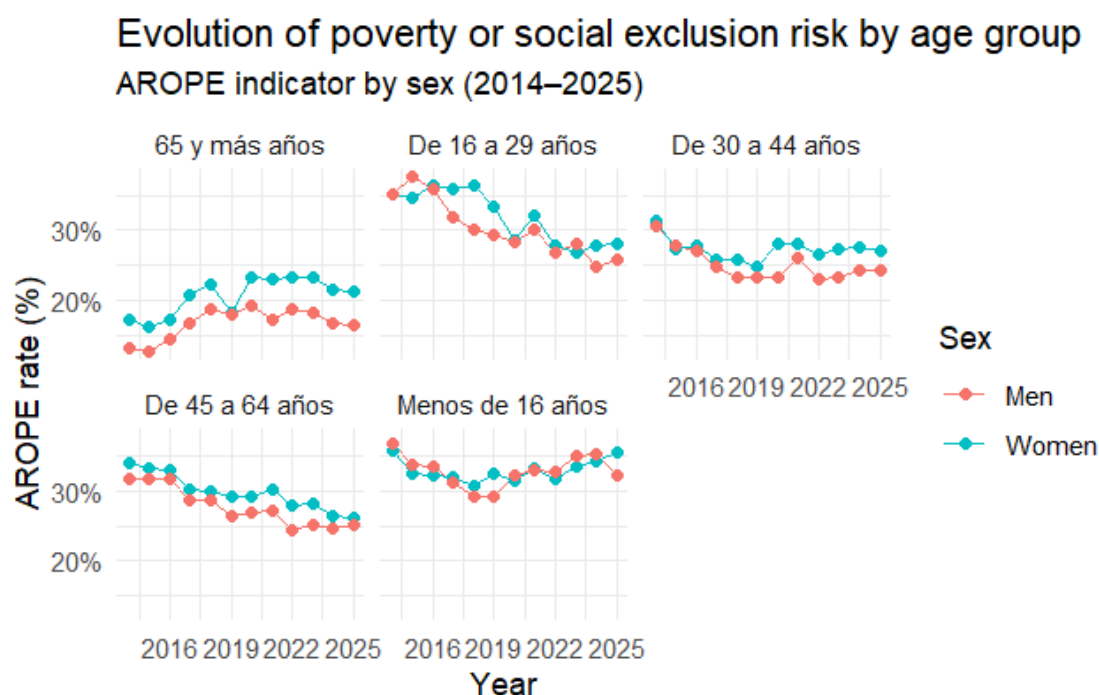
Evolution of poverty or social exclusion risk by sex			
AROPE indicator, Spain (2014–2025)			
Sex	2025	2014	Change (p.p.)
Women	26.8	30.6	–3.8
Men	24.5	29.8	–5.3

Source: author's own elaboration based on data from the Spanish National Statistics Institute (INE), AROPE indicator.

From a comparative perspective, the chart shows that women were consistently more exposed to the risk of poverty or social exclusion throughout the entire period analysed. While the female indicator declines from levels slightly above 30% to around 27% by 2025, the male rate falls from approximately 29–30% to below 25%. This persistent difference suggests the existence of structural inequalities affecting both groups differently, likely linked to unequal labour market trajectories, greater female exposure to economic vulnerability, or broader social dynamics that asymmetrically affect income levels and access to social protection.

However, the chart also suggests a certain degree of convergence relative to the initial levels, as the gap between men and women appears to narrow at certain points during the period, particularly around the middle of the time series, before later stabilising at a relatively constant difference. Overall, the observed pattern points to an aggregate improvement in the indicator, but without the full elimination of persistent gender disparities.

How does AROPE evolve by sex within each age cohort?



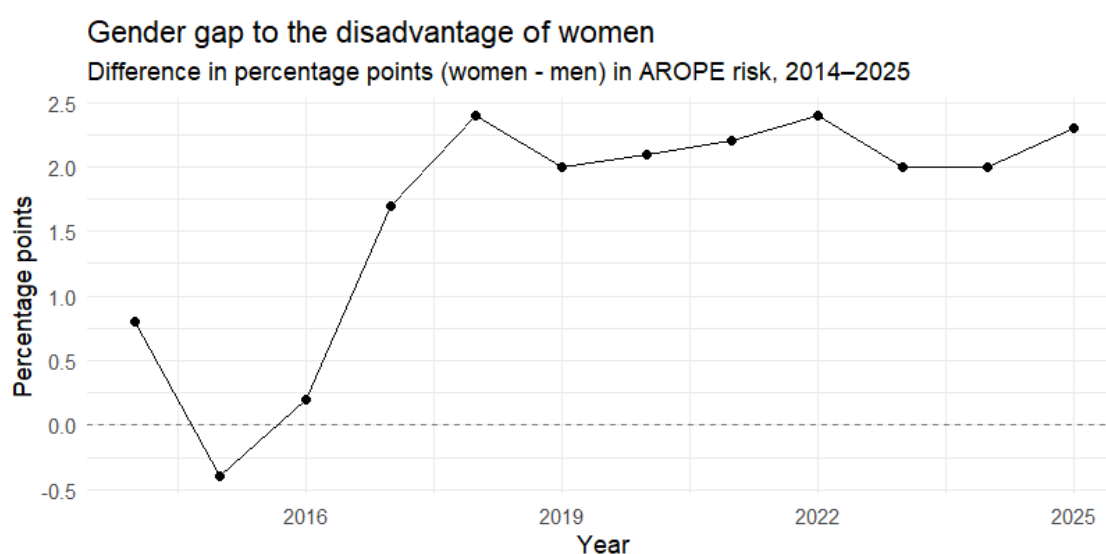
Based on data from the Spanish National Statistics Institute (INE), AROPE indicator.

The evolution of the AROPE indicator disaggregated by age group shows that the risk of poverty or social exclusion is not distributed evenly across cohorts, but instead follows clearly differentiated dynamics depending on life-cycle stage. While some groups experience sustained improvements throughout the period analysed, others display relative stability or even deterioration, pointing to the existence of age-specific structural vulnerabilities linked to socioeconomic position.

The clearest declines are observed among the population aged 16 to 29 and the 45 to 64 age group, although in both cases the pace of improvement appears to moderate in the later years of the series. By contrast, children under 16 show a particularly concerning pattern, remaining the group most exposed to the risk of poverty or social exclusion and even recording levels above those observed at the beginning of the period. The population aged 65 and over also displays an upward trend, albeit from comparatively lower starting levels, suggesting a relative deterioration in their position despite remaining the least exposed group in aggregate terms.

From a gender perspective, differences between men and women remain relatively stable across most cohorts, with women generally displaying higher levels of exposure, although with important variations depending on age group. Gender gaps appear to narrow somewhat among children and younger cohorts, while becoming more pronounced among older populations. Certain temporal discontinuities are also visible—particularly around 2020–2022—potentially consistent both with external socioeconomic shocks, such as the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic, and with methodological adjustments introduced in the measurement of the indicator itself. Overall, the observed pattern suggests that the risk of social exclusion is shaped not only by cyclical economic dynamics, but also by structural factors associated with age, gender, and differing dependence on social protection mechanisms.

Is the gender gap widening or narrowing?



Source: author's own elaboration based on data from the Spanish National Statistics Institute (INE), AROPE indicator.

The evolution of the gender gap in the AROPE indicator shows that the aggregate improvement observed in overall levels of poverty or social exclusion risk has not been accompanied by an equivalent reduction in inequalities between men and women. With the exception of a temporary anomaly in 2015, when the difference narrows and even briefly reverses, the series reflects a clear widening of the gap from 2016 onwards, later stabilising at relatively consistent levels of around two percentage points.

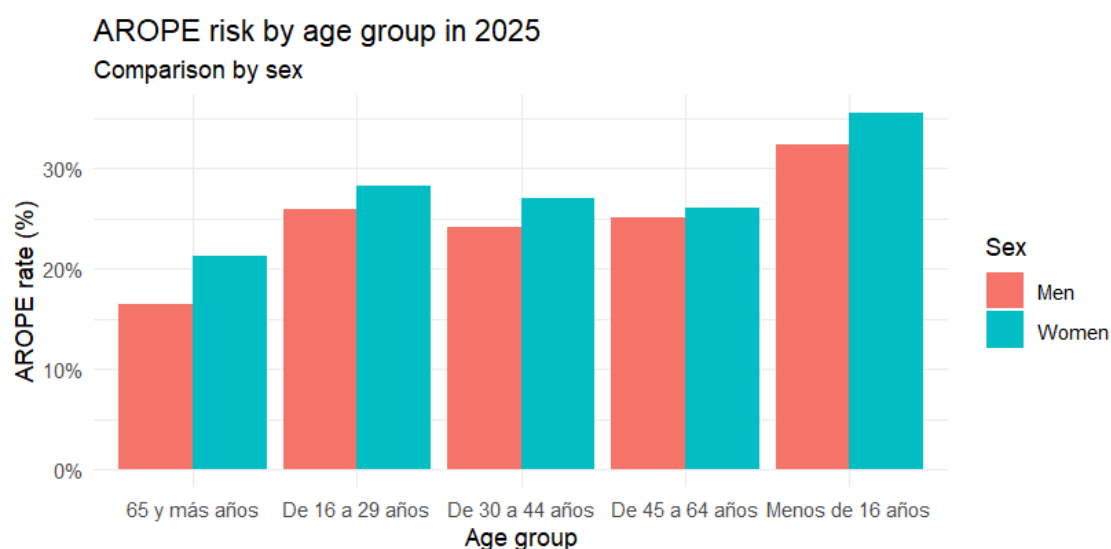
This pattern suggests that, although the overall risk of poverty or social exclusion has declined in Spain over the period analysed, this improvement has not benefited both sexes equally. The persistence of a structural gap to the disadvantage of women points to differentiated exposure to economic and social vulnerability factors, potentially linked to labour market inequalities, wage disparities, the overrepresentation of women in more precarious forms of employment, or unequal burdens related to care responsibilities and economic dependency.

From a substantive perspective, this finding is particularly relevant because it challenges overly optimistic interpretations based solely on aggregate trends in the indicator. A general reduction in AROPE risk does not necessarily imply an equivalent improvement in terms of distributive equity across social groups. In this case, the data suggest that structural gender inequalities continue to shape differential exposure to the risk of poverty or social exclusion in Spain. The evolution of the gender gap in the AROPE indicator shows that the aggregate improvement observed in overall levels of poverty or social exclusion risk has not been accompanied by an equivalent reduction in inequalities between men and women. With the exception of a temporary anomaly in 2015, when the difference narrows and even briefly reverses, the series reflects a clear widening of the gap from 2016 onwards, later stabilising at relatively consistent levels of around two percentage points.

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Which groups are currently the most affected?



Author's own elaboration based on data from the Spanish National Statistics Institute (INE), AROPE indicator.

The 2025 cross-sectional snapshot provides a clear picture of which groups are currently most exposed to the risk of poverty or social exclusion in Spain. The observed pattern reveals a fairly well-defined hierarchy across cohorts: children under 16 constitute the most vulnerable group, followed by the population aged 16 to 29, while those aged 65 and over display the lowest levels of exposure to the AROPE indicator. This distribution suggests that social vulnerability is particularly concentrated in stages of economic dependency or life-course transition.

From a gender perspective, the pattern is equally consistent. Women display higher levels of risk across all age cohorts analysed, although the intensity of the gap varies. The disparity appears particularly pronounced among older populations and children, while narrowing somewhat in intermediate groups such as those aged 45 to 64. Although this chart does not allow for causal inference or the identification of specific explanatory mechanisms, it does provide a clear descriptive picture of persistent inequalities by sex and age.

From a substantive perspective, this finding reinforces the idea that aggregate improvements in the AROPE indicator do not necessarily eliminate internal disparities between population groups. The concentration of risk among children, younger adults, and women points to the existence of differentiated structural vulnerabilities, with clear implications for public intervention and the design of more targeted social policies.

Conclusions

The data analysed reveal clear patterns of inequality that open plausible avenues for future research. The persistence of a gender gap to the disadvantage of women, together with the high exposure of groups such as children and young people to the risk of poverty or social exclusion, raises important questions about the structural factors that may be shaping vulnerability unevenly across these populations. Likewise, the trajectory observed in other groups, such as older populations, suggests specific dynamics that would merit closer examination.

That said, the aggregated nature of the data used limits the explanatory scope of this exercise. While the analysis allows for the identification of robust descriptive patterns and the formulation of plausible hypotheses, it is not sufficient to isolate specific explanatory mechanisms or support strong causal inferences. Advancing this line of inquiry would require working with original individual-level microdata, whether through sources such as EU-SILC/Eurostat or the microdata from Spain's Living Conditions Survey (*Encuesta de Condiciones de Vida*), incorporating additional variables that would allow a more precise examination of factors such as income, labour market status, household structure, or educational attainment.

Sources and methodology

Conceptual and methodological framework (Eurostat / European Union)

- [Eurostat. Glossary: At risk of poverty or social exclusion \(AROPE\).](#)
- [Eurostat. Glossary: At-risk-of-poverty rate.](#)

- [Eurostat. Glossary: Persons living in households with very low work intensity.](#)
- [Eurostat. Glossary: Severe material and social deprivation rate \(SMSD\).](#)
- [Eurostat. Living conditions in Europe: poverty and social exclusion.](#)

Data used (Spain)

- [Instituto Nacional de Estadística \(INE\). Riesgo de pobreza o exclusión social \(AROE\). Datos extraídos de la Encuesta de Condiciones de Vida \(ECV\).](#)